sometimes drew sketches of buildings and presented them to his mother who lovingly preserved these, binding them into albums. But the usually flexible Naval Tata was determined not to give in to his son's aspirations in this case. 'You cannot build a successful career as an architect', Ratan recalls was his father's refrain. The young Ratan was torn between his desire to be deferential to his father and his keenness to pursue his passion.

Ratan cannot, however, quite explain how he came to discover a passion for architecture. Two reasons why he had lost his heart to the profession, however, can be gleaned from his conversations. First was Tata House where he spent his growing up years until the end of his school days when he had to decide on his profession. Though he never doubted the exquisiteness of Tata House, Ratan says he developed a dislike for its opulence, preferring a less ornate style himself. Ratan is, to this day, anything but a sybarite. This is evident in the minimalistic style of his post-retirement house, 'Halekai' (meaning 'house by the sea' in Hawaiian).

The second reason had to do with Durga Shankar Bajpai, the renowned US-educated architect. Bajpai designed the iconic Jehangir Art Gallery at Kala Ghoda and the Tata Institute of Social Sciences (TISS) building at Deonar, both in Bombay. The former was an early example of the 'modernist notion of inward-looking art galleries'. One of the earliest concrete buildings in Bombay, it incorporated diffused lighting in the egg-shaped structure and was considered a harbinger of a new style when it was completed. The TISS building, on the other hand, combined an interesting blend of the features of Indian tradition and modern conveniences. The fact that both these famous buildings were finished around the time that Ratan was completing school and had received considerable publicity in Bombay at that time, may have had some influence on him.

The only way forward was to find a strategic compromise. Engineering became an alternate profession that Ratan was willing to consider. A few years ago, a team of engineers from Kaiser Steel had been involved in the modernization of the Tata Iron and Steel Company (TISCO). Naval Tata was immensely impressed by their technical capabilities and veered to the position that if his son was so opposed to being an accountant, mechanical engineering could be the compromise profession. Ratan acquiesced to this.

Now came the question of which country he should pursue higher studies in. Going to the United States for higher studies was Ratan's dream, one that he had nurtured from his schooldays. When he was eleven years old, he